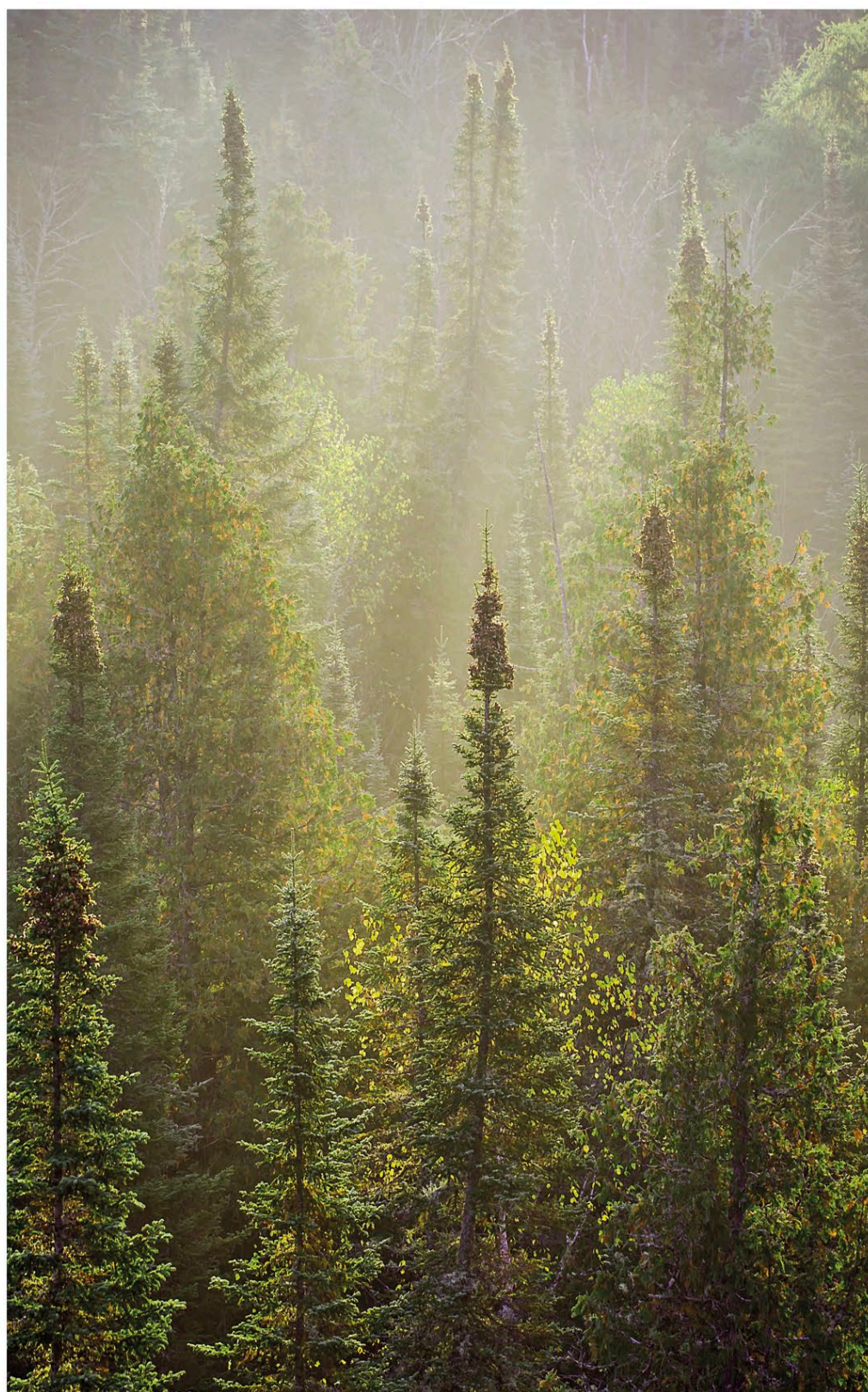


North American Boreal Forest

The largest intact forest on Earth, one of only five that contain expanses of untouched wilderness, and a breeding ground for billions of birds



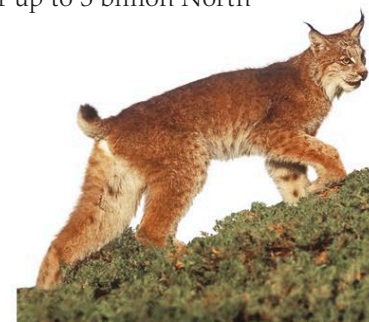
Boreal forest, or taiga, is the world's largest terrestrial biome, consisting of vast expanses of mostly conifer species. In North America alone, 2 million square miles (6 million square km) of boreal forest stretches from Alaska to Newfoundland, and from the Great Lakes as far as the Arctic tundra.

Cold-climate forest

The boreal forest is also known as a snow forest due to its climate. Short, humid summers of 50–100 frost-free days are followed by long, cold winters with up to six months of temperatures below freezing. Precipitation falls mainly as snow. Conifers, such as spruce, are well adapted to survive such rigorous conditions (see panel, below), and they dominate the landscape. Lakes, rivers, and wetlands are numerous, making the North American boreal forest Earth's largest source of unfrozen freshwater. Because it is still relatively intact, this is a vital habitat for wildlife such as moose and brown bears, and a breeding ground for up to 3 billion North American birds.

▷ BOREAL SPECIALIST

The mainly solitary Canadian lynx roams the boreal forest in all seasons, following its primary prey species, the snowshoe hare.



◁ DENSE COVER

Conifers such as spruce, pine, and fir grow close together, forming an almost unbroken canopy that allows little light to reach the forest floor.

SHEDDING SNOW

A conifer's conical shape and flexible, downward-pointing branches prevent heavy snow accumulation. Narrow, needlelike leaves also prevent snow buildup and have a waxy outer coat that prevents water loss by evaporation in freezing conditions.

snow slides off branches when too much builds up

